

PREPARING FOR **DIGITAL WASTE TRACKING**

A practical readiness guide
for UK waste operations



DEFRA RECEIPT OF WASTE API
Production approval testing passed

For waste receiving sites, carriers,
managers and waste producers

Updated August 2026

wastextracking.com



INTRODUCTION

Digital waste tracking is changing how waste receipts are recorded.

The UK is moving from fragmented, largely paper-based waste records towards a central digital reporting service. The first mandatory phase focuses on licensed and permitted waste-receiving sites.

1 OCTOBER 2026

Mandatory receipt reporting begins for permitted and licensed sites in England and Wales.

Northern Ireland and Scotland follow from 1 January 2027.

WHAT THIS GUIDE COVERS

01

Requirements & timelines

Who needs to act first and when.

02

Compliance routes

Defra spreadsheet, API-enabled software, or an internal integration.

03

Operational readiness

The data, people and processes receiving sites should prepare.

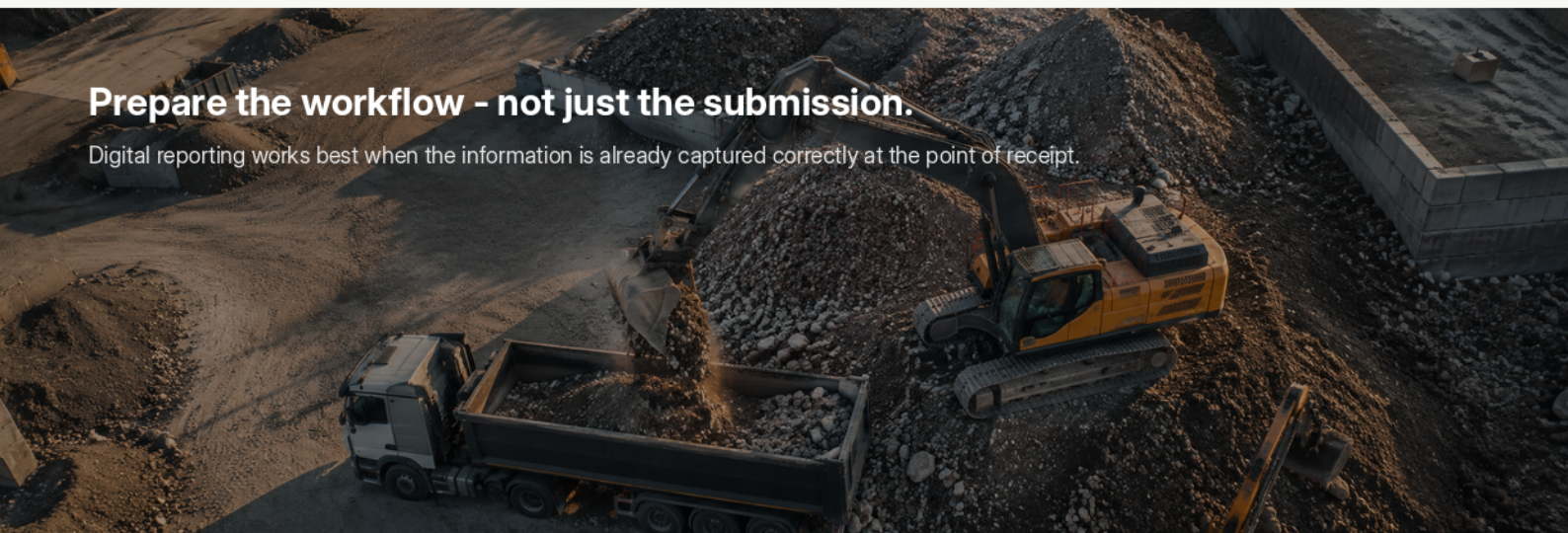
04

How Waste X fits

How one connected workflow can support receipt reporting and wider chain-of-custody operations.

Prepare the workflow - not just the submission.

Digital reporting works best when the information is already captured correctly at the point of receipt.



DWT 101

What is Digital Waste Tracking?

Digital Waste Tracking is the government's phased programme for recording waste movements digitally. The first live service is 'report receipt of waste', focused on data about waste entering licensed or permitted receiving sites.

FOR RECEIPT REPORTING, DEFRA CURRENTLY PROVIDES TWO SUBMISSION ROUTES

01

API-enabled software

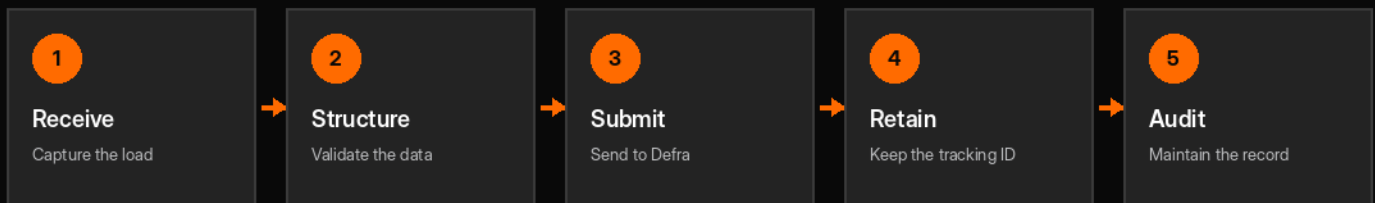
Waste-specific software connects to Defra so receipt data can be sent directly from the operational system.

02

Defra spreadsheet

Sites without compatible software can complete Defra's spreadsheet template and upload the movements.

THE OBJECTIVE



Important:

The new receipt service does not immediately remove every existing waste reporting obligation. Operators should continue following current regulatory requirements alongside Digital Waste Tracking unless official guidance says otherwise.

Waste X focuses on capturing operational data once, retaining an auditable record, and supporting direct submission through the Receipt of Waste API.

TIMELINE

The Digital Waste Tracking rollout

The programme is being introduced in phases. Receiving sites are first, followed by waste collectors. Later stages will extend digital tracking across more of the waste chain.

28 APR 2026

Public beta

Receipt of waste opened for permitted and licensed receiving sites to test voluntarily.

1 OCT 2026

Mandatory - England & Wales

Permitted and licensed sites must report every receipt of waste digitally.

1 JAN 2027

Mandatory - NI & Scotland

Receipt reporting becomes mandatory for permitted and licensed receiving sites.

SPRING 2027

Phase 2 public beta planned

Waste collectors - carriers, brokers and dealers - move into public testing.

OCT 2027

Phase 2 mandatory planned

Digital Waste Tracking is planned to become mandatory for waste collectors.



CURRENT PRIORITY

Receiving-site readiness

OPERATIONAL READINESS

The challenge is bigger than “sending a file”.

Digital reporting introduces a data deadline, but the real pressure sits inside existing site workflows: who captures the information, where it is stored, how it is checked, and who fixes errors.

01

Waste receivers

- Can your team capture every incoming load consistently?
- Can you verify carrier, waste and site information before submission?
- Who owns corrections when Defra rejects a record?

02

Carriers & managers

- Can assignment, collection and vehicle information be linked to the same waste record?
- Can teams share load references without duplicating admin?
- How will later DWT phases fit your current process?

03

Waste producers

- Can you demonstrate where waste went and who handled it?
- Are carrier and receiver authorisations checked?
- Can you retrieve a complete chain of custody for audit or dispute?

The readiness question

Can your organisation produce a complete, accurate receipt record within the reporting window without creating a second administrative process?

CHOOSING A ROUTE

Three practical ways to meet receipt reporting

Defra allows receipt data to be submitted through its spreadsheet or through compatible software connected to the Receipt of Waste API. Larger organisations may also build their own integration.

ROUTE	BEST FIT	STRENGTHS	TRADE-OFFS
Defra spreadsheet	Lower-volume operations	No software integration required. Official template.	Manual preparation and upload. Data may still be duplicated across operational systems.
API-enabled software	Sites wanting integrated workflows	Data can flow directly from waste-specific software to Defra.	Requires compatible software, implementation and internal process change.
Internal API integration	Larger technical teams	Maximum control over internal architecture and integrations.	Development, security, maintenance and regulatory change remain your responsibility.

WHERE WASTE X FITS

Waste X is the API-enabled software route: operational waste records are structured inside the platform, receipt data is submitted through Defra's API, and the resulting record remains connected to the wider chain of custody.

PHASE 1 - WASTE RECEIVERS

Receiving sites are first.

From 1 October 2026 in England and Wales, organisations operating licensed or permitted waste-receiving sites must report every receipt of waste through the new service.

2 WORKING DAYS

Reporting window

from the day after receipt

£26 / YEAR

Defra service charge

per organisation, not per site

EVERY RECEIPT

Scope

report each waste receipt

A RECEIVING-SITE WORKFLOW SHOULD BE ABLE TO

- ☒ Capture the date and time the waste was received
- ☒ Identify the waste and record the required classification information
- ☒ Record weight, container and physical-form information where required
- ☒ Record carrier, vehicle and transport information
- ☒ Identify the receiving site and relevant authorisation
- ☒ Submit the record and retain the Waste Tracking ID
- ☒ Identify and correct failed or incomplete submissions
- ☒ Maintain a clear audit trail for compliance teams

RECEIPT DATA

What information needs to be captured?

The Receipt of Waste API contains required, conditional and optional data fields. The exact rules depend on the movement, but sites should make sure their workflows can reliably capture the following categories.

01 Movement details

Receipt date/time, references and consignment information.

02 Waste classification

EWC codes, waste description and physical form.

03 Containers

Number and type of containers where applicable.

04 Weight

Metric, amount and whether the weight is estimated.

05 POPs & hazardous

Presence, source and relevant component/property information.

06 Carrier & transport

Registration, organisation, vehicle and means of transport.

07 Receiver & site

Site name, address and environmental authorisation number.

08 Recovery / disposal

Relevant disposal or recovery codes and quantities where required.

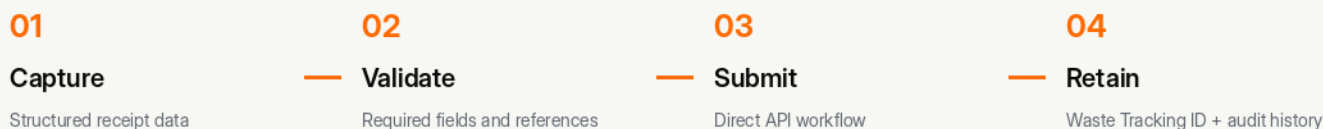
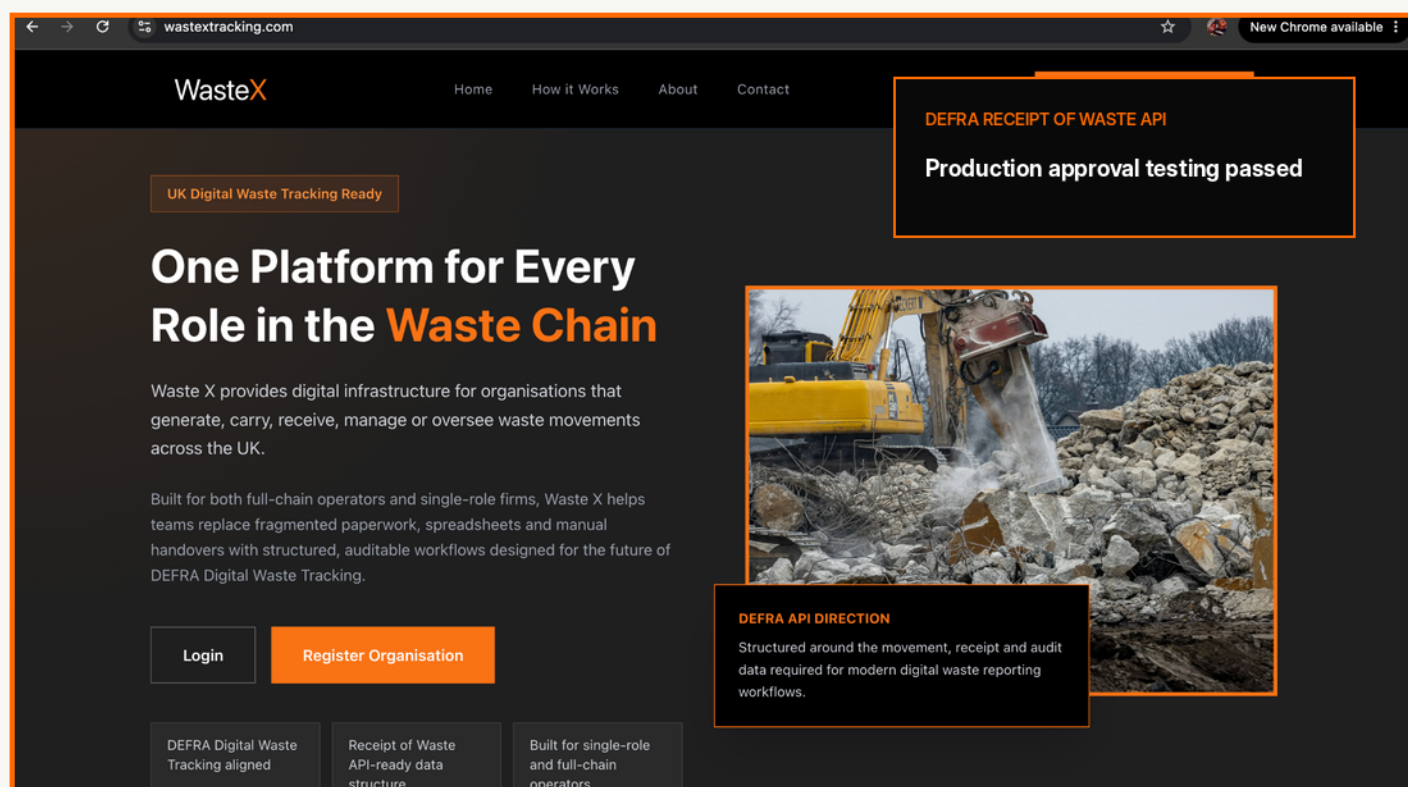
Always check the latest Defra data requirements before implementation.

Field rules may be updated as the service evolves.

WASTE X FOR RECEIVING SITES

From receipt to Defra submission - in one workflow.

Waste X is designed to turn the compliance requirement into part of the operational intake process, rather than a separate reporting task at the end of the day.



The same organisation can also manage assignments, collection activity, incidents, departments and wider chain-of-custody records inside Waste X.

FUTURE PHASES

Carriers, brokers and dealers are next.

Defra currently plans Phase 2 of Digital Waste Tracking for waste collectors – carriers, brokers and dealers – with public beta from spring 2027 and mandatory use planned from October 2027.

01**Autumn 2026**

Private beta planned for an invited group of waste collectors.

02**Spring 2027**

Public beta planned for waste collectors.

03**October 2027**

Mandatory Digital Waste Tracking planned for waste collectors.

WASTE X ALREADY STRUCTURES THE OPERATIONAL SIDE

01**Assign**

Route work internally, directly, or through controlled external workflows.

02**Collect**

Carriers receive assignments and record collection activity.

03**Confirm**

Verification and status changes become part of the audit history.

04**Extend**

Future regulatory submission steps can be added as Defra publishes later-phase requirements.

Later-phase details are still evolving. Waste X will follow published Defra requirements as they mature.

WASTE PRODUCERS & MANAGERS

Digital tracking does not replace duty of care.

In England and Wales, duty of care already applies to businesses that produce, carry, keep, treat, dispose of, import or control waste. Organisations must take reasonable steps to ensure waste is handled lawfully throughout its journey.

CORE RESPONSIBILITIES INCLUDE

01

Authorised parties

Check that carriers, brokers and receiving sites have the correct authorisations.

02

Accurate description

Provide enough information to enable lawful and safe handling of the waste.

03

Traceability

Take reasonable steps to understand where the waste is going and whether it reaches the intended destination.

04

Record keeping

Keep appropriate documentation and evidence of the checks and transfers made.

WHERE WASTE X HELPS

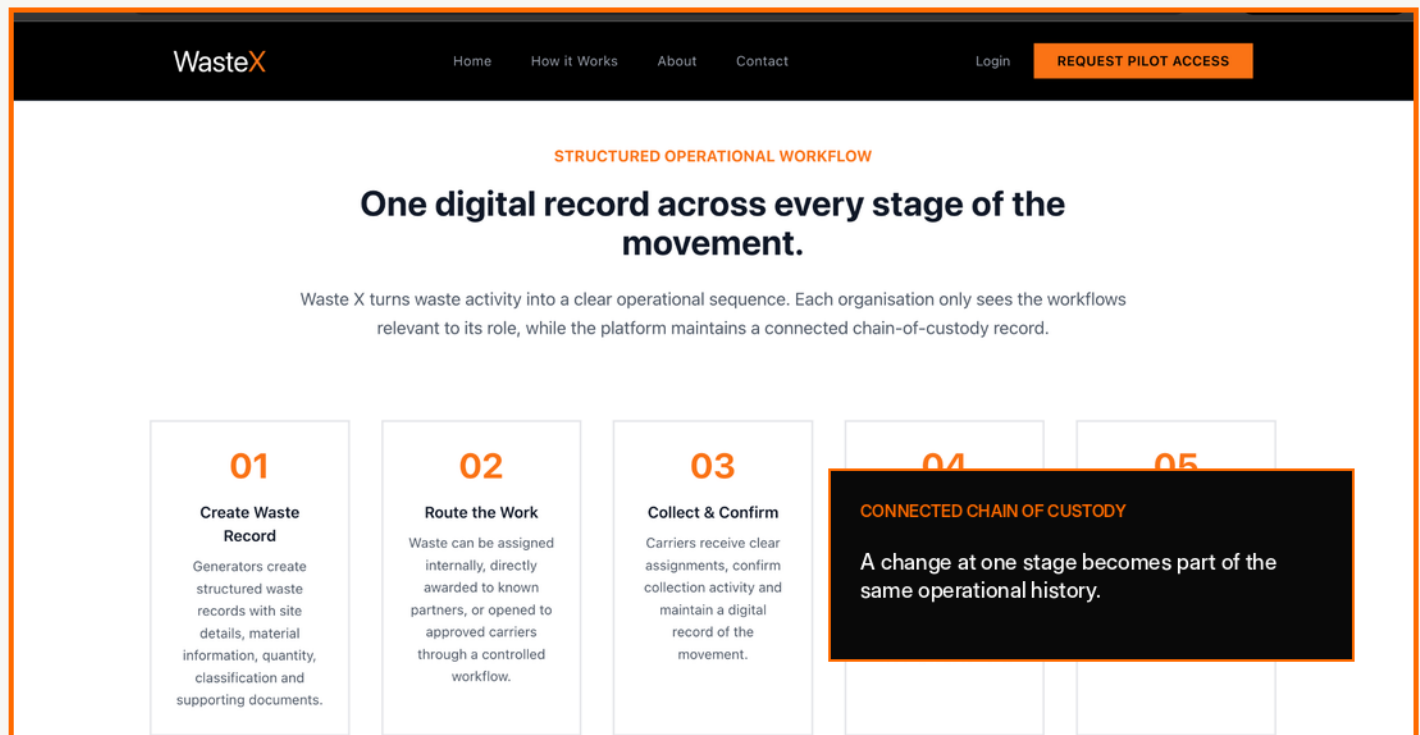
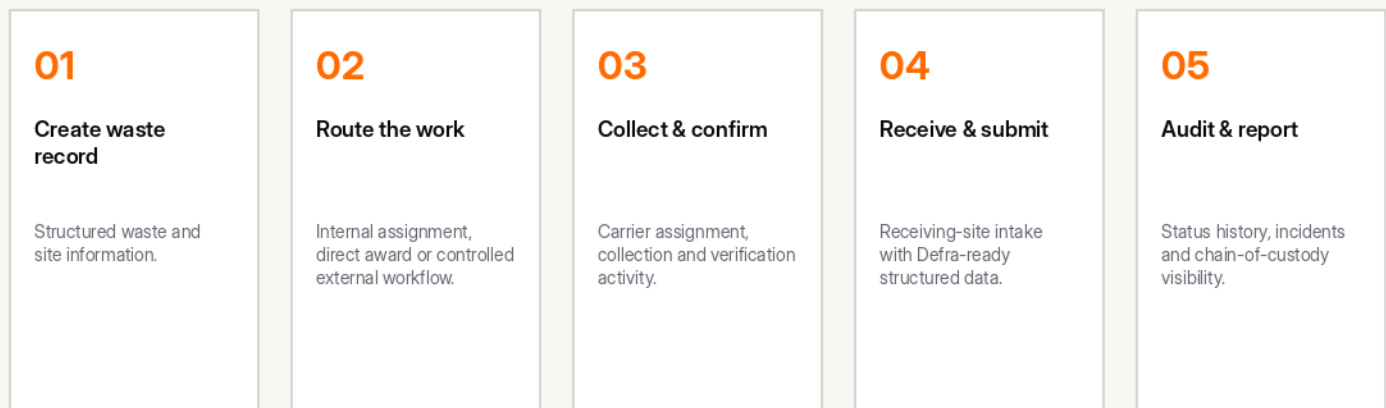
Waste X creates a connected operational record across waste creation, assignment, collection, receipt, incidents and compliance review. That does not remove legal responsibility - it gives teams a clearer evidence trail for meeting it.



THE WASTE X MODEL

One digital record across every stage of the movement.

Waste X is built around the full operational chain, not only the final regulatory submission. Each organisation sees the workflows relevant to its role while the platform maintains a connected audit trail.



BEYOND COMPLIANCE

The value is not just “sending data to Defra”.

The strongest Digital Waste Tracking implementation should improve the operation before it improves the report.

01 Less fragmented admin

Move away from disconnected emails, spreadsheets and paper handovers.

02 Better visibility

See who created, assigned, collected and received each movement.

03 Clear accountability

Role-based workflows make ownership of each stage easier to understand.

04 Faster audit preparation

Keep movement history, incidents and receipt records in a structured system.

05 Scalable operations

Support organisations acting as generator, carrier, manager or receiver without separate systems.

Build compliance into the workflow - not on top of it.

READINESS CHECKLIST

Are you ready for receipt reporting?

Use this checklist to identify the gaps your organisation should close before mandatory reporting begins.

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Confirm which sites are licensed or permitted to receive waste | ☐ Check that all required waste, carrier and site information can be captured |
| ☐ Register the organisation for the Defra receipt service | ☐ Define how failed or rejected submissions will be corrected |
| ☐ Choose API-enabled software, Defra spreadsheet, or an internal integration | ☐ Train gate, weighbridge, operations and compliance users |
| ☐ If using an API, obtain the organisation API code | ☐ Run test movements before the mandatory date |
| ☐ Map the current intake process from vehicle arrival to completed record | ☐ Create a process for monitoring data quality and missing records |
| ☐ Confirm who owns Digital Waste Tracking internally | ☐ Keep the latest Defra guidance under review |

PILOT BEFORE YOU DEPEND ON IT

Use realistic waste movements to test people, data and software together.

ABOUT WASTE X

Built for every role in the waste chain.

Waste X is a UK digital waste management platform helping waste producers, carriers, managers and receiving sites manage waste movements, assignments, receipt records and chain-of-custody workflows in one place.



ABOUT WASTE X

Built for the Future of Digital Waste Tracking

Waste X exists to help UK organisations manage waste movements with better structure, clearer accountability and stronger audit visibility.

The platform is designed for both large organisations managing the full waste chain and smaller firms focused on one role, such as waste generation, collection, transport, receipt or compliance.

DEFRA INTEGRATION

Receipt of Waste API integrated. Production approval testing successfully passed.

PILOT PROGRAMME

We are inviting receiving sites and waste operators to test realistic workflows and help shape the wider launch.

READY TO TEST WASTE X?

Explore the demo or book a pilot conversation.

demo-wastextracking.com • wastextracking.com • tino@wastextracking.com

Disclaimer: This guide provides general information and does not constitute legal or regulatory advice. Digital Waste Tracking requirements can change. Always check the latest guidance from Defra and your environmental regulator.